

8.1 Browser Security

The Web browser is your portal to the big bad world that is the Internet. It's also the easiest way a hacker, spammer, or phisher can attack your computer. An unsecure browser therefore means that the door is open for those with malicious intent to get into your computer, all guns blazing.

Part of the problem is that some Web sites have content that can only be viewed if you install additional software, which puts your computer at further risk of attack. But before we go into how you can effectively secure your browser, let's take a look at what features hackers are looking to exploit.

8.1.1 Getting To Know Your Browser

Why you need to know what you're doing with your browser is that you could inadvertently install a feature that makes it less secure.

Here's a look at the common features that Web browsers have to view content on the Internet. These are common across almost all browsers.

○ **ActiveX:** A technology used by Microsoft IE. It allows different applications, or parts of applications, that you have installed on your computer to be accessed by your browser to display content. These applications may already be in your computer, or they may have to be downloaded. This is where the security threat comes in, because if the ActiveX controls aren't properly implemented, your computer will become seriously vulnerable.

○ **Java:** A language used to develop content for, among other things, Web sites. Content in this case is interactive, wherein there is usually some input from the user. The Java Virtual Machine is used to view Java applet on sites. If you have come across Java content and it played in your browser, you have the JVM installed;

○ **Active Content:** This is generally enabled by plugins installed on your browser to view interactive or dynamic content such as